SESSION PLAN

Keep it, drive into space, attack with width and depth

Men's 2nd XI · Wednesday 11 November

Team / age group	Men's 2nd XI	**Coach**	Head Coach
Date / time	Wednesday 11 November	**Venue / space**	Half pitch (full pitch for blocks 4-5)
Duration	70 mins	**Players**	12-14 outfield + 1 GK
Equipment	Balls x20, Cones (3 colours), Bibs x3 sets, Mini goals x4	**Session focus**	Keep phase: keep the ball and drive into free space. Attack phase: stretch the defence with width and depth to create the chance.

SESSION OBJECTIVES

- Keep the ball under pressure and recognise when to drive into free space
- Hold width (both wide channels filled) and depth (a player high and a player supporting) on every entry to the 23
- Use width and depth to play wide and finish at the back post

KEY MESSAGES / TRIGGER WORDS

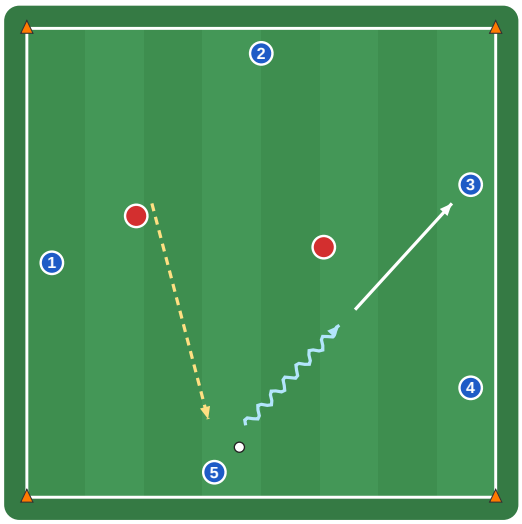
- "Keep it!" - no forced balls, recycle and go again
- "Space - go!" - drive when the defender commits
- "Chalk on boots" - wide players on the sideline
- "Stretch it" - someone high, someone short

SESSION OVERVIEW

Time	Block	Mins
0–10	**Warm-up** Rondo 5v2: keep it, split it, drive it	10
10–23	**Technical** Width and depth pattern: drive, go wide, back-post finish	13
23–36	**Small-sided** 6+1 v 6 + GK: keep zone to attack zone	13
36–50	**Live game scenario** 7v7 live: keep, drive, stretch	14
50–70	**Game** 7v7 full pitch: the width and depth game	20

DIAGRAM KEY

1. WARM-UP: Rondo 5v2: keep it, split it, drive it — 0–10 min (10')



Two grids side by side (x2). 5 keep the ball against 2. When a defender commits, drive into the space and play out.

ORGANISATION / SET-UP

Two 15x15m grids, 7 players per grid (5 outside, 2 defenders inside). With 12 players run 4v2 in each grid. Balls stocked at each corner.

ADAPT IT (STEP)

S Space: Make the grid longer than it is wide to show more space to drive into
P People: 4v2 with 12 players, 5v2 with 14

HOW IT WORKS

• Outside players keep the ball with a two-touch limit.
• A pass that splits the two defenders = 1 point.
• When a defender steps out to press, the player on the ball (or the next receiver) drives into the space he has left and plays out to a team-mate = 2 points.
• Defenders swap in on a turnover or every 60 seconds.

LINK TO THEME

Introduces the Keep phase: keep the ball calmly, and spot the moment a defender commits so you can drive into the free space.

COACHING POINTS

• Open body on receive so you see both defenders before the ball arrives
• Defender steps towards you = space behind him: carry the ball into it
• Drive at pace with the head up, then release early
• Off the ball: move to make a passing angle either side of the ball

PROGRESSIONS (HARDER)

• One-touch unless you are driving
• Shrink to 12x12m

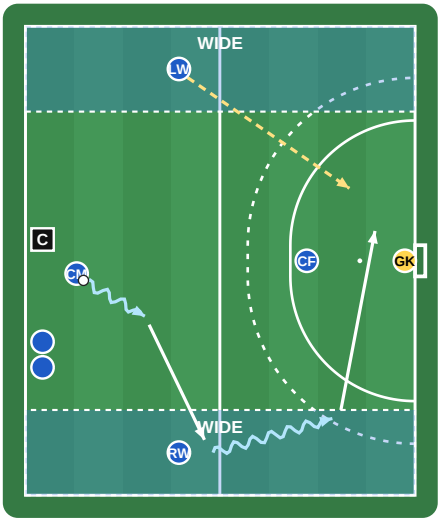
REGRESSIONS (EASIER)

• Three touches allowed
• Defenders at 50% pace for the first two minutes

KEEPING EVERYONE ACTIVE

All 12-14 working in two grids, nobody waiting. Defenders rotate every minute so everyone gets work both ways.

2. TECHNICAL: Width and depth pattern: drive, go wide, back-post finish — 10–23 min (13')



Groups of 4 attack the goal. CM drives into space, plays to the wide player on the sideline, wide player drives and crosses to the high CF or far-side runner.

ORGANISATION / SET-UP

Half pitch with GK. Wide channels coned 10m in from each sideline. Groups of 4 (CM, RW, LW, CF), next group waiting at halfway. With 14, the extra 2 become the semi-opposed defenders.

HOW IT WORKS

• Coach feeds to CM, who drives into the space in front of him.
• RW and LW hold width on the sideline, CF holds depth at the top of the D.
• CM plays wide to RW, who drives to the baseline and crosses to the CF (near post) or LW (back post, who has run in from width).
• Unopposed for 4 minutes, then add 2 red defenders (passive, then live). Alternate the side every rep.

LINK TO THEME

Full walkthrough of the Attack phase: width (both channels filled) and depth (CF high, CM supporting) stretch the defence so the wide ball and the back-post finish are on.

COACHING POINTS

• Wide players: chalk on boots, stay wide until the ball is played to you
• CF stays high to pin the defence: that is the space the CM drives into
• Wide player receives on the move and drives to the baseline, not across the D
• Far-side wide player arrives late at the back post, not early

QUESTIONS TO ASK

• What happens to the defence if both our wingers come inside?
• Where is the space when the CF stays high?

PROGRESSIONS (HARDER)

• Two live defenders plus a third recovering from halfway
• CF can show short (double lead) and the CM plays in behind

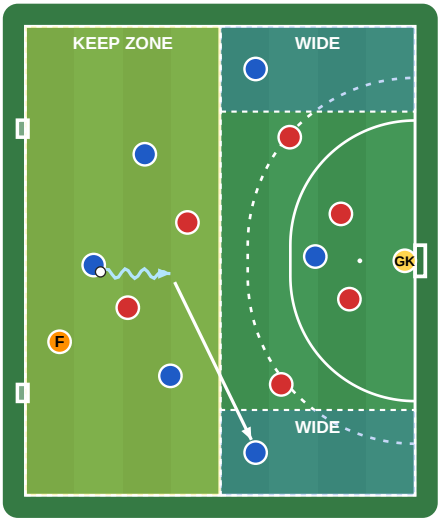
REGRESSIONS (EASIER)

• One passive defender only
• Allow the CM to play straight to the wide player without driving

KEEPING EVERYONE ACTIVE

Next group starts as soon as the previous shot is taken: 3 groups rotating gives about 30 seconds rest. Finished group collects balls and becomes the defenders for the next rep.

3. SMALL-SIDED: 6+1 v 6 + GK: keep zone to attack zone **23–36 min** (13')



Blue (+ orange floater) must keep it in the keep zone, then attack the 23 with width and depth. Red win it and keep it or drive into the mini goals on halfway.

ORGANISATION / SET-UP

Half pitch. Keep zone = halfway to 23m line. Wide channels 10m in from each sideline inside the 23. Blue 6 + 1 floater attack the full goal. Red 6 + GK defend and counter to 2 mini goals on halfway. With 12 players go 5+1 v 5.

ADAPT IT (STEP)

S Space: Widen the channels to 12m to make width easier to find
T Task: Bonus point for any drive that beats a player
P People: Floater changes every role swap

HOW IT WORKS

• Every rep starts with a coach feed to blue on halfway.
• Blue must complete 4 passes OR beat a player with a drive in the keep zone before entering the 23.
• In the 23 blue need a player in each wide channel and one high. Goal = 1, goal from a ball played in from a wide channel = 2.
• Red win it: 5 passes = 1 point, or dribble into a mini goal = 1 point. Swap roles every 4 minutes.

LINK TO THEME

Links the two phases: keep and drive in the middle, then attack with width and depth once you get in.

COACHING POINTS

• Keep zone: if it isn't on, recycle back through the floater, don't force it
• Drive the moment a red midfielder steps out, and commit the next defender
• Before the ball goes into the 23: are both channels filled, is someone high?
• Wide receiver: first touch forward down the line

QUESTIONS TO ASK

• When was the best moment to drive?
• How did their defence react when our wingers stayed wide?

PROGRESSIONS (HARDER)

• Remove the floater (6v6)
• Blue must enter the 23 within 10 seconds of the 4th pass

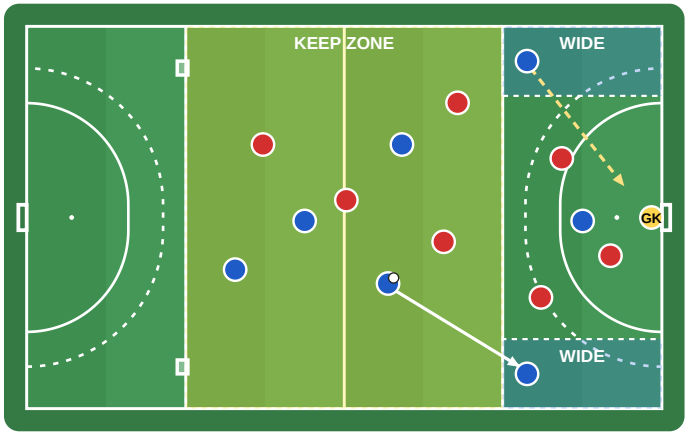
REGRESSIONS (EASIER)

• Floater plays for blue in the attack zone too (7v6)
• Only 2 passes needed in the keep zone

KEEPING EVERYONE ACTIVE

13-14 players all involved, no queue. Coach has balls ready at halfway for an instant restart after each attack ends.

4. LIVE GAME SCENARIO: 7v7 live: keep, drive, stretch — 36–50 min (14')



Play from the left 23 to the right backline. Blue attack the full goal with width and depth, red keep it and attack 2 wide mini goals on the 23. Swap ends after 7 minutes.

ORGANISATION / SET-UP

Three-quarter pitch: left 23m line to the right backline. Wide channels inside the attacking 23. GK in the full goal, 2 mini goals in the wide channels on the 23m line. 7v7 (6v6 with 12).

HOW IT WORKS

• Blue attack the full goal: goal = 1, goal from a ball played in from a wide channel = 2.
• Red attack the mini goals: goal after 5+ passes in the keep zone = 2, otherwise 1.
• Any ball out or goal: coach feeds a new ball straight in to the team that didn't lose it. No waiting for players to get back.
• Swap attacking roles after 7 minutes.

LINK TO THEME

Both phases in a live game: one team practises Attack with width and depth, the other practises Keep and drive out, then they swap.

COACHING POINTS

• Keep phase: patience, switch the ball, then drive into the side that opens up
• Attack phase: width before you enter, depth beyond the ball
• Wide channel ball: drive to the baseline, cross early to the back post
• Transition: lose it, win it straight back

PROGRESSIONS (HARDER)

• Wide channel goals worth 3
• Two-touch limit in the keep zone

REGRESSIONS (EASIER)

• Add a neutral floater for the team in possession
• Remove the 5-pass bonus

KEEPING EVERYONE ACTIVE

Everyone plays for all 14 minutes. Quick coach restarts keep the ball in play. Drinks taken at the swap, not during play.

5. GAME: 7v7 full pitch: the width and depth game — 50–70 min (20')

ORGANISATION / SET-UP

Full pitch, 7v7 (6v6 with 12). GK in one goal; in the other goal a rotating outfield 'kicking back' player (swap every 5 minutes). Wide channels coned 10m in from each sideline in both 23s. Swap ends at half-time.

HOW IT WORKS

• Normal rules, no aerials.
• Goal counts double if the team had a player in both wide channels when the ball went into the D.
• Coach freezes play only for one good example of keep-and-drive and one of width and depth per half.

LINK TO THEME

Full game to see if the Keep and Attack habits stick without heavy conditions.

COACHING POINTS

• Keep it when it's not on: recycle and switch
• Drive into space when a defender commits
• Width and depth before every entry to the 23
• Coach watches: how many attacks have both channels filled? Who stays high?

QUESTIONS TO ASK

• How many of our goals came from width? What made them happen?
• When did we lose the ball forcing it, when we should have kept it?

POST-SESSION REFLECTION

What went well against today's objectives?	
Which players stood out / need follow-up?	
What would I change next time (space, numbers, timings)?	
Carry-over theme for next session:	

SAFETY / WELFARE NOTES

- Shin guards and gum shields for all
- GK fully kitted for blocks 2-5
- No aerials in blocks 3-5; crosses must be kept low
- Kicking-back player in block 5 has no GK kit: no shots above knee height at him